

5. 'It is more important than ever to possess reading skills today.' Discuss.

Keywords

- **More...than ever:** need to compare with the past and show how the modern context has made reading skills more important compared to the past
- **Reading skills:** basic literacy (ability to read by understanding what words mean) and critical reading skills (ability to not only understand meaning but to also think carefully about a subject or idea before accepting it. Critical reading involves analysing claims, the veracity of reasoning and evidence, and possible counterarguments.)
- **Today:** Consider characteristics of the modern context: age of misinformation, prolific use of technology, rising threats to security due to radicalisation, social media, democratisation of the media

Question requirements

- Time comparison or at least contextualisation to the modern context by linking reasons to the characteristics of the modern world
- Students need to consider how the characteristics of the modern world makes it necessary for people to possess reading skills

Conclusion: Despite the increasingly multi-modal nature of modern communication which may render reading skills less relevant, reading skills are still very important given the need to manage the challenges of the modern world.

Suggested Approach

- A. Acknowledge reasons why reading skills may be seen as unimportant today
- B. Provide reasons for why reading skills are important today

Part A: Acknowledge reasons why reading skills may be seen as unimportant today

1. Modern communication is largely dominated by visuals more so than written language to capture the attention of viewers who are deeply immersed in a extremely visual environment.

Example:

A 2017 report by PWC titled The Power of Visual communication reported that in the world of social media, visual content is 40 times more likely to get shared, and articles that feature an image every 75-100 words receive double the social media shares than those with text alone

The dominance of Computer-mediated communication today means that visuals are also widely used for communication.

Example:

The use of stickers, graphic illustrations that communicate sentences or phrases on messaging platforms has surged. On Facebook Messenger alone, users send more than 380 million stickers each day. In a 2017 survey conducted by Harris Poll and commissioned by GIF platform Tenor, 36% of millennials ages 18 to 34 who use “visual expressions” such as emojis, GIFs and stickers say that those images better communicate their thoughts and feelings than words do.

Consequently, in understanding information, reading skills are not as important as viewing skills. In fact, where visuals dominate, reading skills are only secondary in bringing about understanding.

2. In today’s fast paced world where instant gratification is valued, information is often abbreviated for efficiency and summarised for ease of comprehension. Modern journalism practices now often include summaries of the news article for a quick read, articles are presented in the form of lists.

Example: For those who do not want to read entire books, there are apps such as Blinkist which provide fifteen-minute summaries of books.

Since the demands of reading texts have been lowered, the ability to read complex texts may not be very necessary.

3. The rise of technology such as natural language processing (sub-field artificial intelligence involving the application of computational techniques to the analysis and synthesis of natural language and speech) allows information can be read to us.

Example: Voice assistant functions in mobile devices such as Apple’s Siri can read out messages for the user. Language processing technology can ‘read’ and comprehend texts for us and suggest meanings and even replies to the content processed.

Therefore, technology has reduced the need for our capacity to read.

Part B: Provide reasons for why reading skills are important

1. In the age of misinformation, reading skills are important to ensure that one is not deceived by falsehoods which can harm oneself and others.

Example: In the case Covid-19 and medical misinformation, reading skills are important in helping one to make informed decisions about our health and manage the pandemic. As of 2021, the Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (Pofma), Singapore’s fake news law, has been used 33 times since it came into force in 2019. More than half of these instances were for correcting Covid-19 misinformation.

2. With the democratisation of the media, there is a large quantity of information and the variance in quality of information. This is further enabled by widespread use of social media where algorithms result in echo-chambers which reinforce existing opinions through the repetition of related content.

Example: Information about climate change is aplenty across social media platforms, blogs and websites. The sheer quantity of information and inconsistencies in this information can result in confusion and so many rely on algorithms to recommend content which are more aligned to their views. As such, it was found that values, ideologies, and political allegiances affected whether or not an individual would deny climate change. In Western societies, political affiliation is the key factor, with conservative voters more likely to discount climate change.

Reading skills are thus required to manage information overload and safeguard against self-radicalisation.

3. In an increasingly complex world, it has become even more important to raise literacy levels for all. Furthermore, especially in developed societies, rising literacy levels have led to the assumption that most are literate. The lack of reading skills could result in one being left behind in society as proficiency in reading serves an indicator of intellectual ability. As many basic services in modern society require one to be literate, it is important to equip those in developing societies with reading skills to increase social mobility.

Example:

According to UNICEF, the inability of 4 out of 10 children to master reading by the end of Primary school is alarming as reading predicts their ability to gain other foundational, transferable, digital and job-specific skills later on in life. A 2018 paper by the World Literacy Foundation revealed that low levels of literacy correlated with poorer employment opportunities and lower income. As a result, they often face welfare dependency, low self-esteem, and higher levels of crime. Moreover, people with a low level of literacy have limited ability to make important informed decisions in everyday life as they struggle with tasks such as filling out forms and applications, understanding government policies, reading medicine or nutritional labels, and more. It is of utmost importance therefore to promote literacy for all.